

through female descent, of Sir Alexander Cairnes, whose brother, Sir Henry Cairnes, was, prior to his death in 1743, the last surviving representative in the male line of the old family of Cairnes of Cults and Orchardton.* The Tyrone family became extinct in the male line on the death of Captain William Cairnes, in 1740, although his grand-nephew and heir, John Elliot, by direction of his grand-uncle's will, assumed the surname of Cairnes in addition to his own name Elliot.

Thus can Lord Rossmore claim to be the head representative, though through female descent, of John Carnys, of Cults, scutifer to the Earl Douglas in 1421, grandson of William de Carnys, who was of that ilk early in the fourteenth century.

ROSSMORE CASTLE.—The illustration of Rossmore Castle here given is of the front view. The portion in the centre is that built originally by Lord Blaney shortly after the year 1620, and rebuilt by his heir Richard Blaney, afterwards 4th Baron, in 1655. Sir Alexander Cairnes added to the building in 1725. The wing to the right and the square tower and magnificent suite of drawing-rooms abutting thereon, to the left, were built by the 3rd Lord Rossmore.

*Of course, strictly speaking, on the death of Sir Henry Cairnes in 1743, the headship of the family in the male line reverted to his distant cousin the laird of Kipp. On the death of George, the last Cairns laird of Kipp, in 1804, the nominal headship of the family would have devolved upon some descendant of a younger son of some of the Cairneses of Kipp, but unfortunately the actual descent of all of these is not distinctly traceable. It is very possible that William Cairns of Magheraconluce, County Down, ancestor of the Earls Cairns, was a cadet of this family. The last Cairns of Galloway whose unbroken descent in the male line from William de Carnys of 1360 could be traced was William Cairns of Torr, who died in 1860. (See chap. VIII.)

Archdall in his *Monasticon Hibernicum* states that Sir Edward, Lord Blaney, built a castle on the site of the Monastery of Monaghan.¹ If this be correct, which we have no reason to doubt, Rossmore is the successor of the Franciscan Monastery founded by Felim MacBriain MacArdgal MacMahon in 1462.² On the suppression of the monasteries in 1538, that of Monaghan was not immediately closed, though it seems to have been granted to some English adventurer.³ Two years later "the Saxonaig destroyed the monastery and beheaded the garrison and some of the Friars."⁴ Thus ended the religious establishment of Muinechain, after a duration of 78 years.⁵

In the State Papers are several grants to Sir Edward Blaney of the castle and lands of Monaghan.⁶ In 1620, he was created Baron Blaney of Monaghan, and granted the castle of Monaghan⁷ which he was to hold as a Royal Fort, with the proviso "that he was to build another castle with

¹ P. 585. Archdall had personal knowledge of this district, and as he lived within a hundred years of Lord Blaney's time, this statement is probably correct. The meaning of Corlattan, the "hill of the monuments"—the name of the townland in which the castle is situated—corroborates Archdall's statement, as the Monastery of Muinechain, we learn from the Annals of Ulster and the Four Masters, was a noted place of burial.

² Annals of Ulster and of the Four Masters, Anno 1462.

³ Archdall gives his name as Edward Withe, but we cannot find any reference to this effect in the Records.

⁴ Annals of the Four Masters, Anno, 1540. The garrison were possibly followers of the MacMahons who fortified the Monastery against the invaders. The situation, being on a steep hill, would have lent itself admirably to this. However, the Irish word translated "garrison" by O'Donovan may mean "guardian," and refer here to the chief friar. This is the rendering given by Hennessy in the Annals of Lough Cè.

⁵ The *Monasticon Hibernicum* wrongly attributes some very early references to Mucknoe (Castleblaney) in the A.F.M. and A.U. to Monaghan. There is no reference whatever in the Annals to Muinechain prior to 1462.

⁶ Calendar of State Papers, 1615-1625, pp. 284, 300, 301.

⁷ The Castle, which formerly occupied what is now the courthouse in the town of Monaghan. It is first mentioned (A.F.M.) as MacMahon's Castle in 1492, but it or its predecessor was probably of earlier date.



ROSSMORE CASTLE, Co. Monaghan.

From a Photo. by Phillips, Bcl[ist.]

a hundred acres in demesne lands," &c. In compliance with this stipulation, he built a residence at Corlattan, known as "Mount Maria," which may be on the actual foundations of the monastery. Lord Blaney died in 1630, and was succeeded in the title and estates, and in the Governorship of Monaghan Castle, by his son Henry, 2nd Baron.

In the rebellion of 1641, the Irish captured both Monaghan Castle and Mount Maria, as well as Castleblaney—where his lordship and his family were in residence at the time. In this Lord Blaney's depositions taken at Dublin Castle, relating to his sufferings and losses entailed by the sacking of his houses, he refers to "his two houses of Monaghan"—*i.e.*, Mount Maria and Monaghan Castle. Among his goods destroyed or lost were "his plate worth £500, and a library of books estimated at £500."

In the beautiful carved oak panelling in the library at Rossmore, over the mantelpiece, is carved the date 1655, from which it is probable that Richard, the brother and heir of Edward, 3rd Lord Blaney, who became owner of the estate in right of his wife in 1653¹, restored the castle. In 1725 Sir Alexander Cairnes added considerably to it, and over the former principal entrance is carved—

A.C.

MOUNT MARIA,

1725.

¹ The Blaney estate was practically laid waste in the troubles of 1641-1646. Castleblaney and Mount Maria, as well as Monaghan Castle, were pillaged and burned, so that Edward the third Lord was left penniless, and sold the property to Thomas Vincent, a London merchant, in 1653. His brother Richard in the same year married that gentleman's daughter, to whom her father gave the estate as a dowry. Richard Blaney succeeded as 4th Baron on the death of his brother in 1669.

The 2nd Lord Rossmore, in whose time the place was known as "Cortolvin Hills," added to it, and the 3rd Lord built the splendid wing, now the main portion of the castle, and containing the magnificent suite of drawing rooms. The demesne, one of the most beautiful in Ireland, contains many gigantic trees of rare varieties, which, from their age, cannot have been planted later than the days of Mary Cairnes, Lady Blaney, or of her father Sir Alexander.

Reference has been made above to the two sisters of Sir Alexander Cairnes, Frances wife of Captain John Henderson of Donoughmore, County Donegal, and Mary, wife of Colonel Boyd, of County Donegal.

The former had issue—

1. CAIRNES HENDERSON.
2. WILLIAM HENRY HENDERSON, of Donoughmore.
3. JOSEPH HENDERSON.
4. MARGARET, wife of the Rev. Francis Laird, of whom later.
5. AGNES, Mrs. Wrighton.
6. ELIZABETH. Died unmarried, 1717.

CAIRNES HENDERSON, who was mentioned in the will of his uncle William Cairnes as his ultimate heir failing the issue of Lady Blaney, married his first cousin Mary, daughter of Colonel Boyd, and had issue three sons and three daughters, of whom the eldest JOSEPH HENDERSON had an only daughter ELIZABETH, who in 1774 married JAMES SINGER¹, then of the 47th Regiment, and afterwards

¹ Of a family long settled in Co. Down. There are several representatives of the Singers, farmers on the Downshire and Mussendun estates, in the neighbourhood of Annahilt and Dromore.